

RP08

Panchayati Raj in Rajasthan

Rajasthan Polity and Administration now runs at 11-14 questions a paper, ahead of Indian Polity.

Panchayati Raj alone gives 2-3 of them. The near-certain ones: Nagaur 2 October 1959, the officer at each tier, the Article map of Part IX, and the Gram Vikas Adhikari fact - which RPSC asked in 2021 and then asked again in 2023, the same fact in consecutive papers.

Panchayati Raj in India did not begin in Delhi. It began in a village of Nagaur district on 2 October 1959, with Nehru cutting the ribbon. That single fact makes this chapter permanently ours, and RPSC never lets a paper go by without touching it - the date, the district, the officer at each tier, the Finance Commission chairperson, the Article number.

Panchayati Raj in Rajasthan

The origin

- Bagdari village, Nagaur - 2 October 1959
- Inaugurated by PM Jawaharlal Nehru
- CM then: Mohanlal Sukhadia
- Andhra Pradesh second - 11 October 1959
- Balwant Rai Mehta report 1957, NDC approval Jan 1958

The Rajasthan Acts

- Bikaner state panchayat Act 1928 - earliest
- Rajasthan Panchayat Act 1953 - gram panchayats
- Panchayat Samitis & Zila Parishads Act 1959
- Rajasthan Panchayati Raj Act 1994 (Act 13 of 1994)
- Rajasthan Panchayati Raj Rules 1996

Constitutional frame

- 73rd Amendment 1992, in force 24 April 1993
- Part IX - Articles 243 to 243-0
- Eleventh Schedule - 29 subjects
- Term 5 years; age 21; re-election in 6 months

The three tiers

- Gram Panchayat - Sarpanch
- Gram Vikas Adhikari
- Panchayat Samiti - Pradhan
- Vikas Adhikari (BDO)
- Zila Parishad - Zila Pramukh - Chief Executive Officer
- Minimum 9 wards / 15 members / 17 members

Gram Sabha

- Article 243A; sections 8A-8E of the 1994 Act
- All voters of the village - the only permanent body
- At least two meetings a year
- Quorum one-tenth of members

Money

- 243H taxes and Panchayat Fund; 243-I State Finance Commission
- 1st Krishna Kumar Goyal (1994)
- 2nd Hira Lal Devpura, 3rd Manik Chand Surana
- 4th Dr. B.D. Kalla, 5th Dr. Jyoti Kiran
- 6th Pradhyuman Singh - award period 2020-25

Special layers

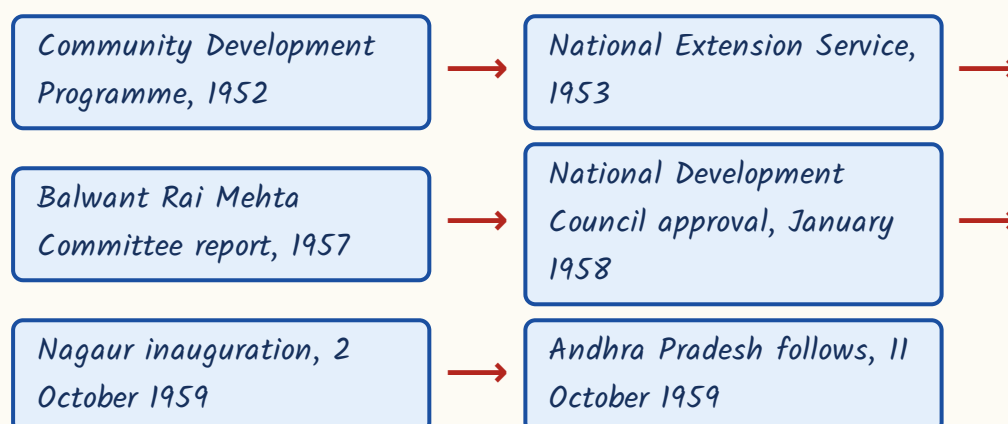
- PESA 1996; Rajasthan PESA Rules 2011
- Scheduled Areas - Banswara, Dungarpur, Pratapgarh full
- Rajiv Gandhi Seva Kendra - built on MGNREGA funds
- eGramSwaraj; national panchayat awards

Rajasthan is where Panchayati Raj began – Nagaur, 2 October 1959

Panchayati Raj means elected local self-government in the villages. India experimented with it after the Community Development Programme failed to involve ordinary villagers. The Balwant Rai Mehta Committee studied that failure and gave the answer in 1957 – democratic decentralisation, a three-tier elected structure. Rajasthan was the first state to actually do it. Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru inaugurated the country's first Panchayati Raj system at Bagdari village in Nagaur district on 2 October 1959. Mohanlal Sukhadia was Chief Minister at the time. Learn the district and the date as a pair – that pair is the single most asked fact in the whole chapter.

- Inauguration: 2 October 1959, Bagdari village, Nagaur district, Rajasthan.
- Inaugurated by Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru; Chief Minister of Rajasthan was Mohanlal Sukhadia.
- Andhra Pradesh was the second state – 11 October 1959, at Shadnagar in then Mahbubnagar district.
- Maharashtra adopted the system only in 1962.
- Balwant Rai Mehta Committee submitted its report in 1957; the National Development Council approved it in January 1958.
- The Committee's phrase for the model was 'democratic decentralisation'.

How the country arrived at Nagaur



ASKED IN RAS

The Nagaur cluster is asked in some form in nearly every paper - the district, the date, the person who inaugurated it, or which state came second. Fix all four together: Nagaur, 2 October 1959, Nehru, Andhra Pradesh.

YAAD RAKHO

Trick to remember: Rajasthan on 2 October, Andhra Pradesh on 11 October, same year 1959 - Gandhi Jayanti first, Andhra nine days later. The Committee is 1957, the approval 1958, the launch 1959 - three consecutive years.

Before 1959 - the princely-state Acts and the Rajasthan

legislation ladder

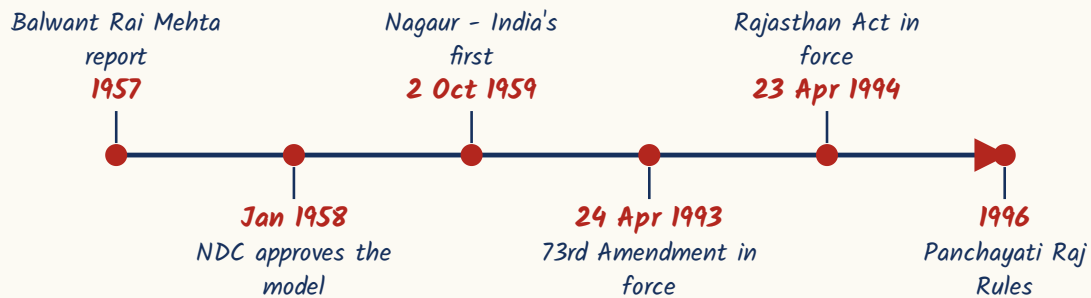
Rajasthan did not start from zero in 1959. Several princely states of Rajputana had already passed village panchayat laws before independence. Bikaner was the earliest, with a village panchayat Act as early as 1928. After integration, the state first unified these scattered laws, then added the upper tiers, and finally rewrote everything after the 73rd Amendment. Read the ladder in order - RPSC asks it as a chronology question.

- Bikaner princely state had a village panchayat Act as early as 1928 - the earliest in the Rajasthan region.
- Jodhpur, Jaipur, Udaipur, Sirohi, Bharatpur and Karauli also had panchayat legislation before independence.
- Rajasthan Panchayat Act, 1953 gave the whole state uniform gram panchayats.
- Rajasthan Panchayat Samitis and Zila Parishads Act, 1959 created the intermediate and district tiers - this is what made the Nagaur launch possible.
- Rajasthan Panchayati Raj Act, 1994 (Act No. 13 of 1994) came into force on 23 April 1994.
- Rajasthan Panchayati Raj Rules, 1996 operationalise the 1994 Act - elections, meetings, committees, conduct of business.

The legislation ladder

Law	Year	What it did
Bikaner state village panchayat Act	1928	Earliest panchayat law in the Rajasthan region
Rajasthan Panchayat Act	1953	Uniform gram panchayats for the whole state
Rajasthan Panchayat Samitis and Zila Parishads Act	1959	Created the Panchayat Samiti and Zila Parishad tiers
73rd Constitutional Amendment Act	1992	In force 24 April 1993; Part IX and Eleventh Schedule
Rajasthan Panchayati Raj Act (Act 13 of 1994)	1994	In force 23 April 1994; the Act in operation today
Rajasthan Panchayati Raj Rules	1996	Procedural rules under the 1994 Act

From the Committee to the Rules - the exact dates



ASKED IN RAS

Panchayat Acts in the princely states are a repeat cluster - asked in 2016, 2018 and again in 2024. The safe answers: Bikaner 1928 is the earliest, and Jodhpur, Jaipur, Udaipur and Sirohi all legislated before independence. Any option saying 'no princely state had panchayat legislation before 1947' is wrong.

TRAP

Do not mix the three Rajasthan Acts. 1953 = gram panchayats only. 1959 = the two upper tiers. 1994 = the whole modern system after the 73rd Amendment. A question saying 'the Rajasthan Panchayati Raj Act was passed in 1959' is wrong - that year belongs to the Panchayat Samitis and Zila Parishads Act.

The constitutional frame - 73rd Amendment, Part IX and the

Article map

Until 1992 panchayats were purely a state subject with no constitutional protection - states dissolved them and did not hold elections for years. The 73rd Constitutional Amendment Act, 1992 fixed that. It inserted Part IX into the Constitution, Articles 243 to 243-O, and added the Eleventh Schedule listing 29 subjects that states may devolve. It came into force on 24 April 1993, which is why 24 April is National Panchayati Raj Day. The Article map is pure marks - it comes as a match-the-following almost every year.

- 73rd Amendment: passed 1992, in force 24 April 1993 - National Panchayati Raj Day.
- Part IX = Panchayats (Articles 243 to 243-O). Part IXA = Municipalities. Do not swap them.
- Eleventh Schedule = 29 subjects for panchayats. Twelfth Schedule = 18 subjects for municipalities.
- The intermediate tier (Panchayat Samiti) is compulsory only in states with a population above twenty lakh - Article 243B.
- Term of every panchayat is 5 years from the date of its first meeting; if dissolved earlier, elections within 6 months (Article 243E).
- Minimum age to contest a panchayat election is 21 years (Article 243F), although the voting age is 18.

Article map of Part IX - first half

Article	Subject
243	Definitions
243A	Gram Sabha
243B	Constitution of Panchayats
243C	Composition of Panchayats
243D	Reservation of seats and of chairperson offices
243E	Duration of Panchayats
243F	Disqualifications for membership

Article map of Part IX – second half

Article	Subject
243G	Powers, authority and responsibilities of Panchayats
243H	Power to impose taxes and the Panchayat Fund
243-I	Constitution of the State Finance Commission
243J	Audit of accounts of Panchayats
243K	Elections to the Panchayats - State Election Commission
243M	Part IX not to apply to certain areas
243N	Continuance of existing laws and Panchayats
243-O	Bar to interference by courts in electoral matters

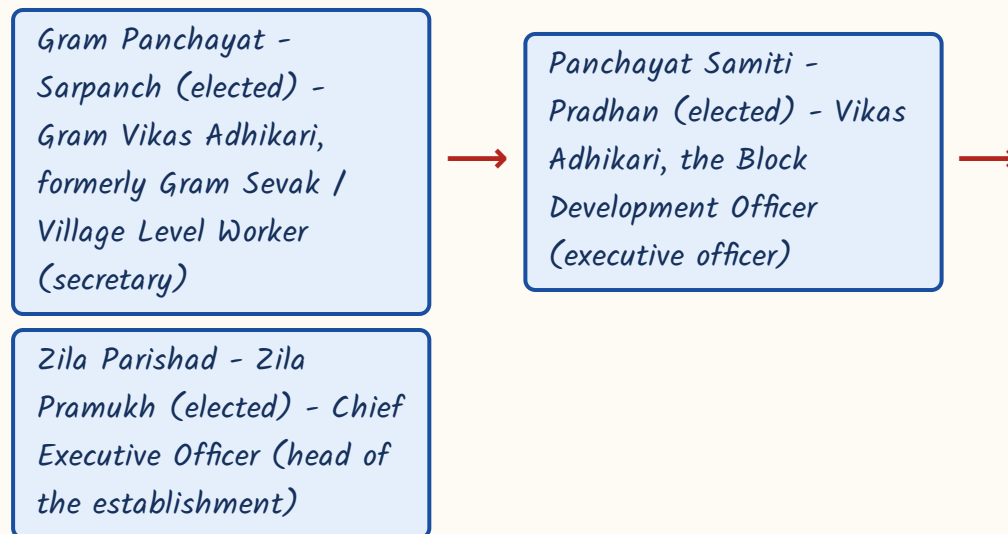
ASKED IN RAS

Article-to-subject matching from Part IX appears constantly. The four that carry the most weight: 243A Gram Sabha, 243D reservation, 243-I State Finance Commission, 243K elections. Learn those four cold and you can eliminate your way through any matching set.

The three tiers – who is elected, who is posted

Every tier has two heads, and RPSC exploits the difference. One is the elected political head, chosen by the people or by the members. The other is the government officer who runs the office and signs the files. Learn them as pairs, tier by tier. This pairing alone has supplied questions in 2021, 2023 and 2024 in one form or another.

The three tiers with the officer at each level



Tier, head, deputy, officer

Tier	Elected head	Deputy	Officer
Gram Panchayat	Sarpanch	Up-Sarpanch	Gram Vikas Adhikari
Panchayat Samiti	Pradhan	Up-Pradhan	Vikas Adhikari (BDO)
Zila Parishad	Zila Pramukh	Up-Pramukh	Chief Executive Officer

- Minimum strength: Gram Panchayat 9 wards; Panchayat Samiti 15 members; Zila Parishad 17 members.
- The Sarpanch is directly elected by all voters of the Gram Panchayat area; ward panchs are elected from single-member wards.
- The Up-Sarpanch is elected by the ward panchs from among themselves.
- Zila Parishad members are directly elected from Zila Parishad constituencies in the district.
- MPs and MLAs representing the area are members of the Zila Parishad; the District Collector is NOT its chairperson.
- The Chief Executive Officer of a Zila Parishad is usually an IAS or a senior RAS officer.

The three tiers - head, officer and electoral unit



ASKED IN RAS

This is the flagship fact of the chapter. The Village Level Worker, also called Gram Sevak, was redesignated Gram Vikas Adhikari - Village Development Officer - and is the secretary of the Gram Panchayat. RPSC asked it in RAS Pre 2021 and then asked the identical fact again in RAS Pre 2023. A fact asked in consecutive papers is a fact that will come back.

TRAP

Gram Vikas Adhikari is NOT Vikas Adhikari. The Gram Vikas Adhikari sits at the village level as secretary of the Gram Panchayat. The Vikas Adhikari is the Block Development Officer at the Panchayat Samiti. And the Chief Executive Officer belongs to the Zila Parishad, never to the Panchayat Samiti - that wrong pairing is a standard 'NOT correctly matched' option.

Gram Sabha - the only permanent body in the system

The Gram Sabha is not elected. It is simply every person whose name is on the electoral roll of a village inside the Gram Panchayat area. Because nobody is elected to it and nobody retires from it, it has no term - which is why we call it the only permanent body of the panchayati raj system. The Constitution recognises it in Article 243(b) and Article 243A, and leaves its powers to be fixed by state law. Rajasthan fixed them in sections 8A to 8E of the 1994 Act.

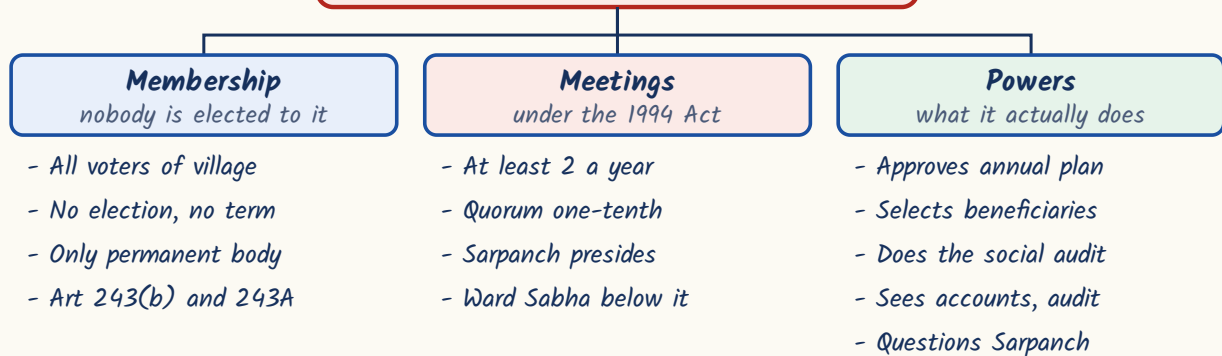
- Article 243(b) defines the Gram Sabha; Article 243A says it shall exercise such powers as the state legislature may by law provide.
- Membership is automatic - every registered voter of the village within the Gram Panchayat area.
- There is no term and no election, so the Gram Sabha is a permanent body.
- The 1994 Act requires at least two meetings a year - one in the first quarter and one in the last quarter of the financial year.
- Quorum is one-tenth of the total members, with SC, ST, backward class and women members present in proportion to their population.
- The Sarpanch convenes and presides; in his absence the Up-Sarpanch; if both are absent, a member chosen by those present.
- Rajasthan also provides a Ward Sabha for each ward of a Gram Panchayat, below the Gram Sabha.

What the Gram Sabha actually does

- Approves the annual development plan and the works of the Gram Panchayat.
- Selects beneficiaries for poverty alleviation and welfare programmes.
- Conducts the social audit of works and expenditure.
- Considers the annual accounts and the audit report of the Gram Panchayat.
- Can demand explanations from the Sarpanch on expenditure and schemes.

The Gram Sabha - who, when and what it decides

Gram Sabha - the only permanent body



ASKED IN RAS

The Gram Sabha statement question is a standard format. Two statements are always true - membership is by electoral roll, and Article 243A recognises it. The false statement planted in these sets is usually 'its members are elected for a term of five years'. They are never elected at all.

Elections, term, reservation and the educational qualification story

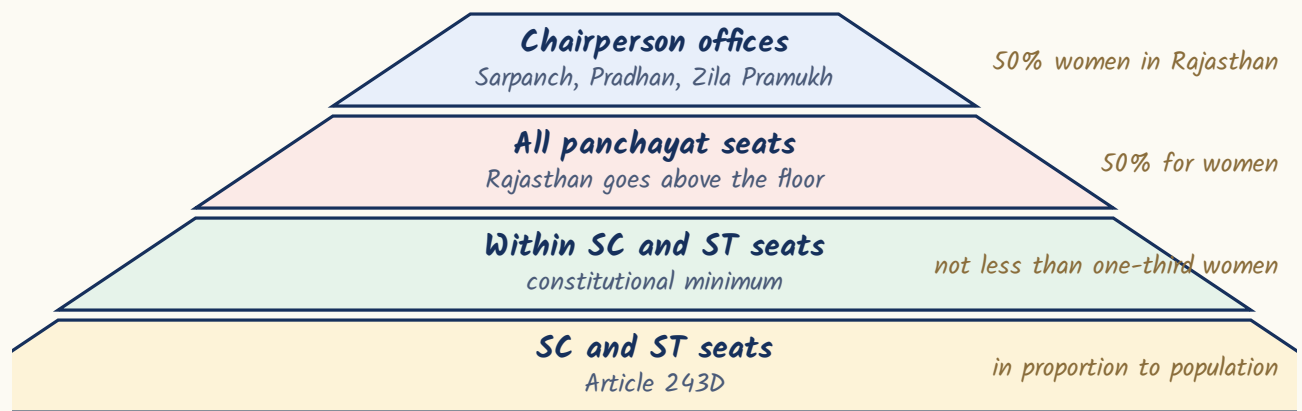
Panchayat elections in Rajasthan are not run by the Election Commission of India. They are run by the Rajasthan State Election Commission, a separate constitutional body under Article 243K, constituted in 1994. Its Commissioner is appointed by the Governor and can be removed only in the manner and on the grounds prescribed for removing a High Court judge - and his conditions of service cannot be varied to his disadvantage after appointment. That protection is the standard question.

- Superintendence, direction and control of panchayat elections vests in the State Election Commission - Article 243K.
- The same Commission runs municipal elections under Article 243ZA.
- The Rajasthan State Election Commission was constituted in 1994.
- Term of a panchayat: 5 years from the date of its first meeting.
- If dissolved early, elections within 6 months; the new body serves only the remainder of the original term.
- A no-confidence motion lies against the Sarpanch, Up-Sarpanch, Pradhan, Up-Pradhan, Zila Pramukh and Up-Pramukh under the 1994 Act.
- It is decided in a specially convened meeting; the required majority and the cooling-off period have been amended more than once, so do not memorise an old number.

Reservation - Article 243D and the Rajasthan addition

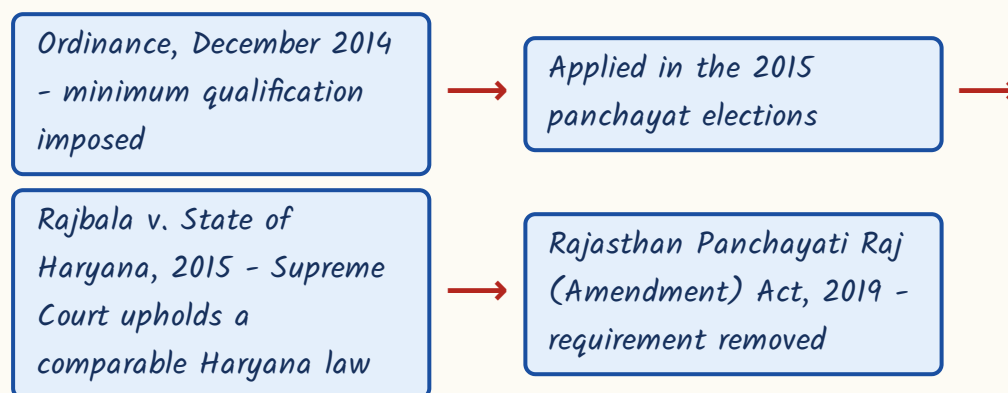
- Seats are reserved for SCs and STs in proportion to their population in the panchayat area.
- Not less than one-third of the seats reserved for SCs and STs must go to women of those categories.
- Article 243D expressly allows reservation of the offices of chairpersons as well - so any option saying the Constitution forbids it is wrong.
- Rajasthan reserves 50 per cent of all panchayat seats for women, above the constitutional minimum of one-third.
- Rajasthan applies the 50 per cent women's reservation to chairperson offices too - Sarpanch, Pradhan and Zila Pramukh.

Reservation - the constitutional floor and the Rajasthan addition



The educational qualification controversy is worth a minute. In December 2014 Rajasthan brought an ordinance requiring a minimum school qualification to contest a panchayat election - the first state in the country to do so. Lakhs of voters, mostly women and mostly poor, became ineligible to stand. The Supreme Court upheld a comparable Haryana law in *Rajbala v. State of Haryana* in 2015, so the rule survived in court. Politics killed it instead: the Rajasthan Panchayati Raj (Amendment) Act, 2019 removed the requirement. Rajasthan was thus both the first to impose it and among the first to withdraw it.

The educational qualification story



Money – taxes, funds and the State Finance Commissions of

Rajasthan

A panchayat that cannot raise or receive money is decoration. So the Constitution gives it two channels. Article 243H lets the state legislature authorise a panchayat to levy taxes, duties, tolls and fees, and creates the Panchayat Fund. Article 243-I requires the Governor to constitute a State Finance Commission every five years to review the finances of panchayats and recommend how state revenues should be shared with them. Article 243J deals with the audit of accounts. Rajasthan has had six State Finance Commissions so far, and their chairpersons are a favourite matching question.

- Article 243H – taxes, duties, tolls, fees and the Panchayat Fund.
- Article 243-I – State Finance Commission, constituted by the Governor every five years.
- Article 243Y extends the same Commission's review to municipal finances.
- Article 243J – audit of panchayat accounts.
- Sources of a Gram Panchayat's income: its own taxes and fees, plus income from panchayat land, ponds and other property.
- Transfers: devolution recommended by the State Finance Commission and grants recommended by the Central Finance Commission.
- Scheme funds – MGNREGA and its successor, central and state schemes – flow through the panchayats but are tied money, not free income.

State Finance Commissions of Rajasthan

Commission	Chairperson	Note
First	Krishna Kumar Goyal	Constituted 1994; award period 1995–2000
Second	Hira Lal Devpura	
Third	Manik Chand Surana	

Commission	Chairperson	Note
Fourth	Dr. B.D. Kalla	
Fifth	Dr. Jyoti Kiran	First woman to chair a Rajasthan SFC
Sixth	Pradhyuman Singh	Award period 2020-2025

ASKED IN RAS

The SFC chairpersons come as a match-the-following or as an ordering question - 'arrange these chairpersons beginning with the earliest'. The order is Goyal, Devpura, Surana, Kalla, Kiran, Pradhyuman Singh. Also remember Article 243-I, not 243H, is the Finance Commission Article.

YAAD RAKHO

Mnemonic for the six SFC chairpersons in order - G-D-S-K-K-P: Goyal, Devpura, Surana, Kalla, Kiran, Pradhyuman. And pair the first with the year the Act came: Goyal 1994, same year as the Rajasthan Panchayati Raj Act.

The committees that shaped panchayati raj

Four national committees and two Rajasthan committees. Learn them as year plus one-line recommendation - that is exactly how the question is framed. The two Rajasthan ones, Sadiq Ali and Girdharilal Vyas, are the ones candidates from other states will not know, so they are your edge.

Committee, year, core recommendation

Committee	Year	Core recommendation
Balwant Rai Mehta	1957	Democratic decentralisation; three-tier structure
Sadiq Ali (Rajasthan)	1964	Reviewed the working of panchayati raj in Rajasthan
Girdharilal Vyas (Rajasthan)	1973	Second Rajasthan review of panchayati raj

Committee	Year	Core recommendation
Ashok Mehta	1977	Two-tier system - Mandal Panchayat and Zila Parishad
G.V.K. Rao	1985	District as the pivot of development administration
L.M. Singhvi	1986	Constitutional status for panchayats; Nyaya Panchayats

Balwant Rai Mehta vs Ashok Mehta

Balwant Rai Mehta, 1957	Ashok Mehta, 1977
Three tiers - Gram Panchayat, Panchayat Samiti, Zila Parishad	Two tiers - Mandal Panchayat and Zila Parishad
Panchayat Samiti is the executive body	Zila Parishad is the executive body
The single village panchayat is the base unit	Mandal Panchayat covers a cluster of villages, 15,000-20,000 people
Political parties kept out	Open participation of political parties recommended
Implemented from Rajasthan, 1959	Largely not implemented at the national level

ASKED IN RAS

Committee-to-year and committee-to-recommendation matching are both asked. The trap option is L.M. Singhvi paired with 1992. Singhvi reported in 1986; 1992 is the year of the 73rd Amendment itself.

TRAP

Do not credit the L.M. Singhvi Committee with the three-tier model - that is Balwant Rai Mehta. Singhvi's contribution was the demand for constitutional status, which became the 73rd Amendment six years later.

PESA, the scheduled areas and the delivery layer

Part IX does not automatically apply to the Fifth Schedule Scheduled Areas - Article 243M keeps it out. Parliament therefore passed the Panchayats (Extension to the Scheduled Areas) Act, 1996, always called PESA. PESA extends Part IX to those areas with modifications, and the key modification is that the Gram Sabha becomes powerful rather than advisory - it must be consulted on land acquisition and resettlement, it manages minor forest produce and minor water bodies, and it approves plans and beneficiary lists. Rajasthan notified its own PESA Rules in 2011.

- PESA, 1996 - extends Part IX to Fifth Schedule Scheduled Areas with modifications giving primacy to the Gram Sabha.
- Rajasthan notified the PESA Rules in 2011 - Rajasthan Panchayat Raj (Modification of Provisions in their Application to the Scheduled Areas) Rules.
- Fully Scheduled Area districts in Rajasthan: Banswara, Dungarpur and Pratapgarh.
- Parts of Udaipur, Rajsamand, Chittorgarh, Sirohi and Pali districts are also inside the Scheduled Areas.
- Article 243M is the Article that keeps Part IX out of those areas until PESA extends it.

Where PESA applies - the Scheduled Areas



The schemes that run through the panchayats

- MGNREGA, 2005 guaranteed 100 days of unskilled manual work per rural household per financial year, delivered in Rajasthan through the panchayati raj institutions.
- Under MGNREGA the Gram Sabha recommends the works and the Gram Panchayat plans and implements them at village level; at least half the works by value are executed through Gram Panchayats.
- Rajiv Gandhi Seva Kendras were built at gram panchayat and panchayat samiti level, largely from MGNREGA funds - they house the panchayat office, records and e-services.
- eGramSwaraj is the Ministry of Panchayati Raj's unified planning, accounting and monitoring application for panchayats.
- The Ministry of Panchayati Raj also confers the national panchayat awards, given on National Panchayati Raj Day, 24 April.

CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026: MGNREGA, 2005 has been repealed and replaced by the Viksit Bharat - Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) Act, 2025, which received assent on 21 December 2025 and raises the employment guarantee from 100 to 125 days. Any question in December 2026 that says '100 days' as the current guarantee is testing whether you have updated.

CURRENT LINK

Current link, as of September 2026: Rajasthan carried out its largest ever reorganisation of panchayats in November 2025, redrawing gram panchayat, panchayat samiti and zila parishad boundaries so that every one of the 41 districts has a zila parishad. The state cabinet has also adopted a 'One State One Election' policy - panchayat and urban body elections to be held together, with the process to be completed by 17 November 2026.

Panchayats whose terms expired in the meantime are being run by administrators. Carry the direction of the change and the date; verify the final numbers close to the exam.

REVISION RECAP

1. Panchayati Raj inaugurated 2 October 1959 at Bagdari village, Nagaur, by Nehru - first in India; CM Mohanlal Sukhadia.
2. Andhra Pradesh second, 11 October 1959; Maharashtra 1962.
3. Balwant Rai Mehta report 1957 - democratic decentralisation, three tiers; NDC approval January 1958.
4. Bikaner state panchayat Act 1928 is the earliest in the region; Jodhpur, Jaipur, Udaipur, Sirohi, Bharatpur, Karauli followed before 1947.
5. Rajasthan Panchayat Act 1953 - gram panchayats. Panchayat Samitis and Zila Parishads Act 1959 - upper tiers.
6. Rajasthan Panchayati Raj Act 1994, Act 13 of 1994, in force 23 April 1994; Rules 1996.
7. 73rd Amendment 1992, in force 24 April 1993 - Part IX, Articles 243 to 243-O, Eleventh Schedule with 29 subjects.
8. 243A Gram Sabha, 243D reservation, 243E duration, 243F disqualification, 243H taxes, 243-I SFC, 243J audit, 243K elections, 243-O bar to courts.
9. Sarpanch - Gram Vikas Adhikari; Pradhan - Vikas Adhikari (BDO); Zila Pramukh - Chief Executive Officer.
10. Gram Vikas Adhikari replaced the Village Level Worker / Gram Sevak - asked in RAS Pre 2021 and again in 2023.
11. Minimum strength: 9 wards in a Gram Panchayat, 15 members in a Panchayat Samiti, 17 in a Zila Parishad.
12. Gram Sabha - all voters of the village, no term, the only permanent body; two meetings a year; quorum one-tenth.

13. Term 5 years from first meeting; re-election within 6 months of dissolution; minimum age 21.
14. Rajasthan State Election Commission, 1994, Article 243K; Commissioner removable only like a High Court judge.
15. Rajasthan reserves 50 per cent of panchayat seats for women, above the constitutional one-third.
16. Educational qualification imposed by ordinance December 2014, upheld in spirit by Rajbala 2015, removed by the 2019 Amendment Act.
17. Six State Finance Commissions - Goyal, Devpura, Surana, Kalla, Jyoti Kiran, Pradhyuman Singh (2020-25).
18. Committees: Balwant Rai Mehta 1957, Sadiq Ali 1964, Girdharilal Vyas 1973, Ashok Mehta 1977, G.V.K. Rao 1985, L.M. Singhvi 1986.
19. PESA 1996; Rajasthan PESA Rules 2011; fully scheduled districts Banswara, Dungarpur, Pratapgarh.
20. Rajiv Gandhi Seva Kendras built with MGNREGA funds; eGramSwaraj is the national panchayat IT platform.